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Displaced by Degrees: Gaps in Laws and Lives

Sheetal Sharma

Introduction

Around 35 million new internal displacement event were generated by weather-related disasters across the global South between 2020 and 2024, this was just one event ,Which not even includes the far larger population adjustments which have been driven by slow onset processes like desertification of pastoral zones, salinisation of agricultural land, increasingly deepening groundwater depletion, attrition of coastal and riverine communities caused by erosion and tidal inundation (IDMC, 2024; Clement et al., 2021). Similar things have been observed through the instances of reshaping human mobility across the global south. Due to which large number of people are in motion, and they are migrating and establishing themselves not in villages or cities but on unplanned urban fringes, which are structurally under-resourced, institutionally fragmented and already in pressure with their current population. This isn't happening randomly, but these are the structured responses coming because of environmental dangers. They are arriving at urban centers which neither anticipating them nor having the institutional capacity to absorb them, and hence it is generating a concentrated vulnerability. The world governments are still not ready and the governance structure is misaligned with the realities people are facing because of climate change.

The title "Displaced by Degrees: Gaps in Laws and Lives" metaphorically explains the situation and central argument of this chapter. "Displaced by degrees" refers to the insidious migration happening because of the climate-induced Disasters i.e. all the consequences of rise in temperature. Meanwhile "Gaps in Laws and Lives" infers to the deficiencies in governance mechanism and legal frameworks, which consequently hampers the lives of not only those who are migrating but the people of the host regions too and hence strain the resources and social fabric, exacerbate human suffering, conflicts and fuels cycles of poverty in the receiving region.

The importance of this chapter in current scenario is more than ever before. Keeping the need and necessity of contemporary time in mind, this chapter is focused on five main objectives: The first aim of this chapter is to address the governance mechanism and its legal framework failure that decides whether the arrival of migrants will build a foundation for social integration or it will reproduce the dangers that displacement was a response to, in urban areas and the host region as well.

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This chapter is going to figure out the dynamics, consequences and governance responses to the migration happening into cities of the global south due to climate change.

This topic has become significantly important since the publication of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) Sixth Assessment Report in 2022, which says that around 1 billion people could be displaced due to the impacts of climate change within their own country by 2050. Report has also mentioned that it depends on the emissions trajectories and adaptive capacity (IPCC, 2022). Now it needs to be understood that these figures reflects the fundamental epistemic challenge of a field in which the edges between environmental acquisition, social vulnerability and economic rationality are deeply entangled. There is a deep institutional vacuum as nothing has been designed with the climate displacement kept in mind, neither international refugee law, national migration policy, nor urban planning frameworks.

This chapter makes the case that the relationship between climate migration and urbanization represents a paradigmatic site of compounding failure—environmental, institutional, and political—and that in order to effectively address it, urban citizenship must be rethought, international climate finance must be reorganized, and new integrated urban planning tools must be developed. These arguments are presented in seven more sections. The conceptual underpinnings of climate migration studies are examined in Section 2, which highlights the slow-onset/sudden-onset contrast and challenges environmental determinism. The structural deficiencies of receiving cities in the Global South are examined in Section 3. In order to facilitate comparative theme analysis, Section 4 provides an empirical examination of three regional case clusters: Bangladesh, the Sahel, and the Mekong Delta. In Section 5, it is examined how governance failures act as social amplifiers, transforming physical displacement into long-term marginalization. Critical deficiencies are identified, and current policy solutions are assessed in Section 6. The Adaptive Urban Integration Model, a novel conceptual framework with operationalized indicators and multi-scalar policy levers, is presented in Section 7. Reflections on climate justice and a research agenda for the future round off Section 8. The geography of climate migration (Black et al., 2011; Rigaud et al., 2021); urban governance theory in the Global South (Parnell & Oldfield, 2014; Mitlin & Satterthwaite, 2013); political ecology (Robbins, 2020); and the literature on the humanitarian–development nexus (Barbelet, 2021) are some of the established bodies of scholarship that this chapter is positioned within but also purposeful dialogue with. It aims to provide an integrative viewpoint that does not lose sight of structural political economics or limit climate migration to environmental determinism.

2. Conceptual Foundations: Rethinking Climate Migration

2.1 Beyond Environmental Determinism

It is both comprehensible and analytically hazardous to interpret climate-induced migration through an ecologically deterministic lens, in which physical stressors mechanically cause predicted population migrations. Early contributions to the topic, such as the seminal work of Norman Myers (1993), proposed that huge refugee flows would result from environmental degradation, a thesis whose empirical weakness has been thoroughly shown (Bettini, 2013; Rigaud et al., 2021). The issue is not that climate stressors do not cause migration, as there is increasing empirical evidence that they do (Cattaneo et al., 2019; Clement et al., 2021), but rather that they do so in ways that are mediated by institutional context, political economy, social norms, and household livelihood strategies. Farmers in the Vietnamese Mekong Delta and coastal Bangladesh may experience comparable levels of salinity intrusion, but their decisions to migrate will be influenced by national social protection systems, kinship networks, land tenure arrangements, credit availability, and the extent to which their governments have made investments in infrastructure for adaptation (Dun, 2022; Ahmed et al., 2021).

A more fruitful starting point for analysis is the migration systems approach (de Haas, 2021).
Instead of viewing migration as a reaction to specific environmental circumstances, this viewpoint vi ews migration as a structural process inherent in historically formed economic, political, and social li nkages between sending and receiving areas.
When applied to climate migration, this method focuses analytical attention on the structural factors —such as poverty, tenure insecurity, and a lack of social protection
that make some populations more vulnerable to displacement brought on by climate change while als o limiting their options for migration (Barnett & Webber, 2010; Zickgraf et al.,
2021).
According to this interpretation, migration is often the final option for those who are already margina lized rather than their desired adaptive reaction.

2.2 Slow-Onset versus Sudden-Onset Drivers

Slow-onset versus sudden-onset environmental stressors are conceptually different, and this distinction has major policy implications. Cyclones, floods, and storm surges are examples of sudden-onset catastrophes that garner disproportionate policy and media attention, leading to well-developed but frequently insufficient emergency humanitarian responses. Sea level rise, progressive soil degradation, shifting rainfall patterns, and an increase in the frequency of droughts are examples of slow-onset stressors that develop over seasons and years, gradually undermining livelihoods and causing migration flows that are difficult to directly link to climate change but have significant overall effects (Black et al., 2011; IPCC, 2022). Since many slow-onset displacements are categorized as voluntary economic migration, the International Displacement Monitoring Center estimated that slow-onset stressors contributed to roughly 32.6 million internal displacement events worldwide in 2022. This estimate significantly underestimates the true scale (IDMC, 2023).

For governance, this classification issue is crucial. Climate migrants lose their eligibility for humanitarian protections and are shut out of financing streams for climate adaption when they are categorized as voluntary economic migrants. They may be eligible for temporary humanitarian aid when they are categorized as disaster-displaced, but they are not included in development planning tools. As a result, most climate-displaced individuals in developing nations are left in an institutional void due to a regulatory deficit (Zickgraf et al., 2021; Warner & Afifi, 2014).

2.3 Migration as Adaptation and Definitional Debates

Over the past ten years, there has been a considerable analytical push to rethink migration as a type of adaptation rather than an adaptation failure (Black et al., 2011; Barnett & Webber, 2010). According to this perspective, moving out from high-risk or environmentally degraded locations is a sensible, often multigenerational household strategy that lowers vulnerability to climate risk and diversifies revenue sources through remittances. This viewpoint casts doubt on the widely held belief in humanitarian and development discourse that migration is a policy failure that can be avoided by in-situ adaptation.

However, there is a risk of analytical overreach with the migration-as-adaptation concept. Many migrations are forced, traumatic, and result in poverty rather than resilience; not all migration is adaptive (Piguet, 2022). Furthermore, migration may create governance issues at the receiving end that jeopardize overall social welfare even when it is successful as a household-level adaptive strategy. This is especially true when cities are unable to accept migrants without escalating urban poverty, informality, and resource competition (Mitlin & Satterthwaite, 2013). Recognizing the adaptive potential of migration while theorizing the structural circumstances that lead to marginalization is an analytical difficulty.

The terrain of definitions is still up for debate. Nearly all people displaced by climate change are not included in the 1951 Refugee Convention's definition of refugee, which is based on persecution

(UNHCR, 2023). Table 1 summarizes the legal, political, and normative weight of several formulations, such as environmental refugee, climate migrant, and climate-displaced individual.

Table 1: Definitional Typology of Climate-Displaced Populations

Category	Legal Status	Primary Driver	Policy Implications
Refugee	Protected under 1951 Convention	Persecution / conflict	Non-refoulement; asylum processing
Environmental Refugee	Contested; no binding definition	Sudden environmental disaster	Humanitarian relief; temporary shelter
Climate Migrant	None; movement often voluntary	Slow-onset stressors (SLR, drought)	Development finance; social services
Internally Displaced Person (IDP)	Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement	Conflict, disaster, or development	National govt responsibility; urban planning
Climate-Displaced Person	Emerging; UNHCR 2023 guidelines	Compound climate–conflict stressors	Rights-based integration; climate finance

Source: Compiled by authors from UNHCR (2023), IOM (2022), Zickgraf et al. (2021), Warner & Afifi (2014). Note: legal status designations reflect prevailing international frameworks as of 2024.

According to Rigaud et al. (2021), the lack of a legally enforceable international terminology for climate-displaced people is a structural governance vacuum with significant material ramifications rather than just a terminological annoyance. It exempts the international community from any legally binding obligation of care while allowing governments to classify climate migrants as voluntary migrants ineligible for protection. A fundamental prerequisite for the governance reforms discussed throughout this chapter is closing this gap, either by turning the non-binding principles of the Global Compact for Migration into legally binding obligations or by creating a climate displacement protocol under the UNFCCC.

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3.The Receiving City: Urban Governance in the Global South

3.1 Structural Deficits of Secondary Cities

The Global South's cities are not all the same. Even if their benefit distribution is incredibly uneven, megacities like Lagos, Jakarta, or Mumbai have garnered significant scholarly and policy attention and, in certain cases, have created sophisticated urban planning organizations. However, the majority of climate migrants covered in this chapter relocate to the peri-urban peripheries of secondary and tertiary cities, such as the industrial periphery of Phnom Penh, the northern communes of Bamako, or Mirpur and Korail on the outskirts of Dhaka, where service provision is scarce and governance deficiencies are most severe.

A number of structural traits that secondary cities in developing nations have in common exacerbate the governance issue of climate in-migration. First, they are usually left out of national political economy of urban investment since secondary cities lack the political clout to reroute resources, and budgetary transfers from central governments are tailored to key cities (Parnell & Oldfield, 2014). Second, their own-source income capability is restricted: municipal bonds are uncommon; property tax systems are often nonexistent, badly run, or politically hindered; and user fees are limited due to population poverty (Mitlin & Satterthwaite, 2013). Third, compared to their primary equivalents, they often have poorer planning institutions, such as fewer computerized land registries, smaller technical personnel, and less advanced interdepartmental cooperation (Reckien et al., 2023).

3.2 Informality, Peri-Urban Growth, and Revenue Constraints

In the Global South, informality is the predominant mode of urban expansion. According to UN estimates, there are presently 1.1 billion people living in informal settlements worldwide; without systematic intervention, that number is expected to rise to 3 billion by 2050 (UN-Habitat, 2022). The majority of climate migrants enter cities through unofficial means, settling in unplanned, often hazardous regions without building licenses, title documents, or utility connections. The main area of climate migrant settlement is the peri-urban periphery, where urban and rural land regimes meet in ways that are legally unclear (Satterthwaite et al., 2020).

This informality is a political situation more than just a lack of preparation. Because landlords, politicians, and slum lords profit from the rents produced by tenure insecurity and from the political clientelism that information asymmetry permits, informal settlements continue to exist (Davis, 2006; Mitlin & Satterthwaite, 2013). Due to their lack of social capital and economic vulnerability, climate migrants are disproportionately vulnerable to exploitative informal housing arrangements and are routinely left out of formal urban planning processes (Ahmed et al., 2021; Satterthwaite et al., 2020).

There are significant and self-reinforcing revenue limits. Without revenue, cities cannot upgrade informal settlements; homeowners without official tenure cannot earn money from them; and inhabitants won't invest in their homes without tenure security. Climate in-migration exacerbates the typical upgrading trap by bringing more people into already resource-constrained informal regions more quickly than even well-run upgrading programs can keep up (Barbelet, 2021; UN-Habitat, 2022).

3.3 Political Economy of Urban Exclusion

Climate migrants are structurally marginalized politically in receiving cities; this is not an accident. Municipal administrations, whose electoral incentives are structured around settled constituencies, are politically invisible to migrants who do not have social networks, official employment, or voter registration in the receiving city. The 'voluntary' framing of climate migration exacerbates this invisibility since governments and planners lack the institutional authority to address in-migration when they fail to acknowledge climate compulsion as the cause (Zickgraf et al., 2021; Piguet, 2022). Thus, the political economy of urban exclusion functions both at the level of regular political practice and at the level of formal institutional design, such as the lack of planning mandates that are inclusive of migrants.

the deliberate undercounting of migrant populations in service delivery goals, budgetary allocations, and censuses (Reckien et al., 2023).

4. Empirical Landscape: Three Regional Cases

Figure 1: Estimated Internally Displaced Persons by Climate Factors — Selected Global South Regions (2023, millions)

South Asia (incl. Bangladesh)		**14.2M**
Sub-Saharan Africa (Sahel + East Africa)		**11.8M**
SE Asia (Mekong + Pacific)		**8.6M**
Latin America (Central Am. + Andes)		**5.9M**
Middle East & North Africa		**4.3M**

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Source: IDMC Global Report on Internal Displacement (2023); World Bank Climate Migration Report (2022); OCHA (2024). Note: Figures represent estimated stock of internally displaced persons with primary climate causality attribution. Methodological caveats apply — see text.

4.1 Bangladesh: Coastal Erosion and the Dhaka Periphery

Bangladesh's geography—low-lying, riverine, heavily populated, and exposed to the Bay of Bengal—makes it particularly vulnerable to the compounding effects of sea level rise, cyclone intensification, riverbank erosion (char land loss), and salinity intrusion, making it perhaps the most studied case of climate-induced internal migration worldwide (Ahmed et al., 2021). The nation has some of the highest rates of internal displacement in the world. According to the IDMC (2023), between 2020 and 2023, there were about 3.4 million internal displacement events that were mostly caused by climate-related factors; however, the underlying stock of climate-displaced individuals who have not returned to their original communities is much larger and more challenging to measure.

The majority of Bangladesh's climate migrants are absorbed by the Dhaka metropolitan region, with peri-urban communities like Korail, Rayer Bazar, Mirpur, and the bastees (informal settlements) of Demra being among the main destinations (Ahmed et al., 2021). The Dhaka Structure Plan 2016–2035 includes provisions for climate-related in-migration, but it lacks the financial resources, land acquisition authority, and implementation mechanisms necessary to operationalize them. These areas have grown at rates well beyond Dhaka's formal planning capacity (Hasan & Mulamoottil, 2021). In peri-urban Dhaka, land tenure is characterized by overlapping claims—state, private, and customary—that consistently disadvantage newcomers, who usually find housing through unofficial rental markets at exorbitant prices and under continual fear of eviction (Ahmed et al., 2021).

Several of the structural problems discussed in this chapter are articulated by the responses of the government of Bangladesh to climate induced-migration. A national IDP policy does not exist. The Bangladesh Climate Change Trust Fund, the Ministry of Housing and Public Works, and the Ministry of Disaster Management and Relief all function without official data exchange or coordinated directives pertaining to climate migration. Although it covers managed retreat and delta governance, the Bangladesh Delta Plan 2100, a historic long-horizon planning document, views migration more as a danger that has to be controlled than as an adaptive response that needs to be supported (Hasan & Mulamoottil, 2021). Programs for participatory upgrading, such as those funded by Dustha Shasthya Kendra (DSK) and BRAC, have shown efficacy at the community level, although they are implemented at far smaller scales than the extent of the demand (Barbelet, 2021).

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4.2 Sahel Cities: Drought, Conflict, and Bamako/Niamey

The Sahel region has an exceptionally complex level of problems Because of conflict dynamics and displacement brought on by climate change are inextricably linked. Millions of agro-pastoralists in Burkina Faso, Mali, Niger, Chad, and Senegal have seen their livelihoods undermined by the desertification of agricultural and pastoral zones, which is caused by decreasing rainfall, soil degradation, and increasing desertification (Zickgraf et al., 2021). Compound displacement that defies single-category analysis is created when this ecological stress combines with intercommunal conflict over dwindling water and pasture supplies, insurgencies connected to Islamist armed organizations, and state fragility (OCHA, 2024).

Niger is one of the world's poorest nations, with per capita public spending on urban services among the lowest in Sub-Saharan Africa, which exacerbates the governance issue in Niamey (World Bank, 2022). The already precarious frameworks of international development aid and urban service delivery have been further upended by Niger's post-2023 political upheaval. Urban service programs that specifically targeted in-migrants affected by climate change had severe budgetary shortages as a result of the loss of bilateral financing from the European Union and France after the 2023 coup (OCHA, 2024). The vulnerability of governance structures that rely on outside funding without internal institutional anchoring is demonstrated by this scenario. Sahelian cities showed some of the lowest levels of climate-migrant-inclusive urban planning of any geographic cohort examined, according to a seminal multi-city examination of climate governance in developing cities by Reckien et al. (2023). Less than 12% of the cities examined had mainstreamed migration as an urban planning element, despite the fact that 78% of them had some kind of urban climate risk assessment.

4.3 Mekong Delta: Vietnam and Cambodia

A third unique pattern of migration brought on by climate change is the Mekong Delta, which is shared by Vietnam, Cambodia, and, to a lesser extent, Laos and Thailand. The main cause of climate migration in the Mekong Delta is the progressive, slow-onset combination of saltwater intrusion, land subsidence (accelerated by groundwater extraction), and increasing flood frequency—processes that have been methodically documented by the World Bank (2022) and Clement et al. (2021). This is in contrast to the situation in Bangladesh, where episodic cyclones compound slow-onset stressors, or the Sahel, where climate–conflict overlap predominates.

Over the past 20 years, there has been a considerable out-migration to the industrial periphery of Ho Chi Minh City from Vietnam's Mekong Delta, which is home to almost 17 million people (Dun, 2022).

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There are significant governance ramifications to the government's portrayal of this movement as labor migration motivated by economic opportunity rather than displacement brought on by climate change. The National Climate Change Adaptation Strategy of the Vietnamese government has not systematically addressed the rights and service needs of Delta-origin migrants in the factory dormitory zones of Ho Chi Minh City, despite being substantial in its engineering provisions (seawalls, drainage, mangrove restoration) (Dun, 2022). Although Vietnam's social insurance system theoretically covers labor migrants, many Delta migrants are essentially shut out of urban social security due to coverage gaps and portability issues (IOM, 2022).

Similar displacement from riverine flooding and the collapse of the fishing industry due to upstream dam building and climate-driven flow anomalies are occurring in Cambodia's lower Mekong Delta. Although Cambodia's civil registration system does not break down migration reasons, Phnom Penh is home to a significant number of rural-urban migrants, some of whom are relocated due to climate change (IOM, 2022). Cambodia's limited civil society space further complicates the governance setting by limiting the participatory planning techniques that have been proposed as essential to inclusive urban government for migrants (Parnell & Oldfield, 2014).

4.4 Comparative Thematic Analysis

The governance analysis produced in the following sections is structured by a number of cross-cutting elements that appear in all three regional instances such as Compound causality, where Environmental, economic, and political stresses combine in context-specific ways are what drive climate migration in all three areas rather than isolated incidents. Single-driver attribution-based governance solutions routinely perform poorly. Second would be Urban absorption without integration where Receiving cities take in climate migrants through the growth of informal settlements, but they lack the institutional, financial, and legal means to incorporate them into political processes, labor markets, and urban service systems. Thirdly, Definitional exclusion where Climate migrants are routinely excluded from humanitarian protections and development planning obligations because they are categorized as voluntary economic migrants in all three situations. Then Gendered dimensions which implies that Due to their varying susceptibilities to hazard exposure as well as the gendered labor demands of managing informal settlements and rebuilding households, women in all three case areas incur disproportionate consequences of climate displacement (Reckien et al., 2023). Lastly the Dependency on external funding which means When donor priorities change or political upheavals disrupt aid flows, urban climate governance in all three areas becomes structurally vulnerable due to its heavy reliance on foreign development assistance.

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Table 2: Comparative Regional Case Summary — Climate Displacement and Urban Governance

Region/City	Primary Stressor	Estimated Displaced (2020–2024)	Urban Destination	Key Governance Gap
Bangladesh (Dhaka periphery)	Coastal erosion, cyclones, salinity ingress	~3.4 million (IDMC, 2023)	Korail, Rayer Bazar, Mirpur slums	No national IDP policy; informal land tenure
Sahel (Bamako, Niamey)	Desertification, crop failure, conflict overlap	~2.1 million (OCHA, 2024)	Peri-urban zones without services	Dual crisis (climate + conflict) defies single-ministry response
Mekong Delta (HCMC, Phnom Penh)	Saltwater intrusion, subsidence, flooding	~1.9 million (World Bank, 2022)	Industrial corridors, factory dormitories	Labour migration framing excludes climate causality from policy
Cross-cutting	Compounding slow-onset + sudden events	~7.4 million (aggregate)	Informal peri-urban settlements	Siloed ministries; absent climate–urban finance linkage

Source: Authors' compilation from IDMC (2023), OCHA (2024), World Bank (2022), IOM (2022), Dun (2022), Ahmed et al. (2021), Zickgraf et al. (2021). Figures are estimates subject to methodological variation.

5. Governance Failures as Social Amplifiers

5.1 Legal Statelessness and Administrative Invisibility

The lack of legal recognition of climate-displaced individuals as a separate administrative category with defined rights and entitlements is the most basic governance failing in climate migration. Without this acknowledgment, climate migrants live in a legal limbo where they are administratively invisible in the receiving city yet technically residents of their home community, entitled to rights they can no longer enjoy. Without civil registration in the receiving city, migrants are unable to vote or take part in municipal governance; they are also legally vulnerable to eviction and arbitrary treatment by landlords, employers, and officials (UNHCR, 2023; Rigaud et al., 2021). This administrative invisibility has far-reaching practical consequences.

5.2 Housing Insecurity and the Eviction Cycle

In the Global South's periurban locations, informal rental markets take advantage of climate migrants' tenure instability. Migrants who lack legal title or occupancy rights are vulnerable to eviction on a regular basis by landlords looking for better-paying tenants, developers turning unused land into commercial space, or municipal authorities carrying out clearance operations disguised as urban development (Satterthwaite et al., 2020; Mitlin & Satterthwaite, 2013).

5.3 Labour Market Exclusion

As formal sector employment usually requires educational credentials, social connections, and legal documentation that recent migrants lack, therefore climate migrants in the Global South primarily enter urban labor markets through the informal sector, such as street vending, construction, domestic work, and rickshaw pulling (Zickgraf et al., 2021). High vulnerability is a characteristic of work in the informal sector, which lacks social insurance, retirement benefits, accident compensation, and minimum wage laws. Migrants who have made contributions to social insurance in their home communities are unable to access those benefits in receiving cities due to the non-portability of social security entitlements across subnational jurisdictions, a structural feature of social protection systems in Bangladesh, Mali, Vietnam, and Cambodia alike (IOM, 2022; World Bank, 2022).

5.4 Gendered Dimensions of Displacement

Climate displacement is not gender-neutral. Women experience differential vulnerability at several stages: when male members migrate first, they are more likely to be left behind in climate-exposed origin communities; when they do migrate, they are more vulnerable to gender-based violence in transit and in informal settlements; and in receiving cities, they are concentrated in the most precarious forms of informal employment with the least social protection, such as domestic work, clothing manufacturing, and food vending (Reckien et al., 2023). Among groups of climate migrants, households led by women are especially at risk: According to Reckien et al. (2023), compared to male-headed migrant families under the same environmental displacement pressures, female-headed migrant households in Sahelian peri-urban zones had much less access to official housing, social protection, and health facilities.

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Table 3: Governance Failure Typology — Mechanisms of Marginalisation

Failure Type	Manifestation	Affected Population	Illustrative Example
Legal Statelessness	No IDP policy; migrants registered as 'voluntary' movers	Climate IDPs without legal status	Bangladesh: displaced coastal communities lack land rights in Dhaka (Ahmed et al., 2021)
Housing Insecurity	Eviction from informal settlements; no tenure rights	Renters in peri-urban zones	Vietnam: factory workers displaced by Delta flooding in industrial dormitories (Dun, 2022)
Labour Market Exclusion	No portability of social security; informal sector traps	Working-age migrants	Mali: seasonal migrants from drought zones excluded from urban social protection (Zickgraf et al., 2021)
Gendered Marginalisation	Women disproportionately in unpaid domestic work; GBV risk	Women and girls	Sahel cities: female-headed households in peri-urban Niamey face heightened insecurity (Reckien et al., 2023)

Failure Type	Manifestation	Affected Population	Illustrative Example
Child Welfare Gaps	Interrupted schooling; child labour; stateless children	Children of displaced families	Cambodia: Mekong children lacking civil registration (IOM, 2022)
Institutional Siloing	No data-sharing between climate, urban, migration ministries	All displaced populations	Cross-regional: contradictory interventions (Rigaud et al., 2021)

Source: Authors' synthesis from Reckien et al. (2023); Rigaud et al. (2021); Zickgraf et al. (2021); Ahmed et al. (2021); IOM (2022); UNHCR (2023). Examples are illustrative, not exhaustive.

6. Policy Responses: Inventory, Evaluation, and Gaps

There has been some response to the governance shortcomings listed in Sections 3 through 5. At the local, national, and international levels, a variety of policy tools have been created and put into use with differing levels of ambition, coherence, and efficacy. This part lists the main tools, assesses how well they work in relation to the structural issues noted, and pinpoints the crucial gaps that make up the policy agenda for this chapter.

Table 4: Policy Instrument Inventory — Assessment Framework

Policy Instrument	Scale	Key Strengths	Critical Gaps	Assessment
Managed Retreat Programmes	National / local	Reduces exposure in high-risk zones	Inadequate compensation; cultural dislocation; underfunded relocation sites	Partial

Policy Instrument	Scale	Key Strengths	Critical Gaps	Assessment
Urban Climate Resilience Plans (e.g., CRPP, 100RC)	City-level	Multi-hazard framing; private sector engagement	Rarely address migrant rights or informal settlements	Partial
National Adaptation Plans (NAPs)	National	Links climate and development goals	Rarely include migration as adaptation pathway	Weak
Participatory Upgrading Programmes (PRODEL, BRAC)	Local / community	Community ownership; incremental improvement	Slow to scale; funding dependent on NGOs	Moderate
Green Climate Fund (GCF) Projects	International	Large capitalisation; project diversity	Infrastructure bias; excludes social protection / governance	Weak
Global Compact for Safe Migration (GCM)	International norm	Migration as adaptation recognised (Obj. 2)	Non-binding; no compliance mechanism	Weak
Humanitarian–Development Nexus frameworks	International	Bridges relief and development timelines	Inadequate for slow-onset climate displacement	Emerging

Source: Authors' assessment drawing on Barbelet (2021), Rigaud et al. (2021), Satterthwaite et al. (2020), GCF Project Database (2024), UNHCR (2023). Assessment ratings (Strong/Moderate/Partial/Weak/Emerging) reflect authors' synthesis of available evaluation evidence.

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6.1 Managed Retreat Programmes

In national adaptation planning, managed retreat—the deliberate movement of residents from high-risk regions to safer locations—is becoming more and more common, especially in riverine and coastal environments. Among the most well-researched instances are the Vietnamese government's Delta Resettlement Program and Bangladesh's Cyclone Preparedness Program (Hasan & Mulamoottil, 2021; Dun, 2022).

6.2 Urban Climate Resilience Plans

Since the mid-2010s, municipal-level urban climate resilience planning has grown significantly, partly due to international initiatives like UN-Habitat's City Resilience Profiling Program, the C40 Cities network, and the Rockefeller Foundation's 100 Resilient Cities project. Establishing multi-hazard risk assessments, including resilience thinking into urban master plans, and encouraging private sector investment in urban climate adaption are all made possible by these frameworks (UN-Habitat, 2022). Systematic assessments, however, show that resilience frameworks often fail to incorporate climate migration. Less than 8% of the 327 municipal climate action plans reviewed by Reckien et al. (2023) included any specific provisions for people displaced by climate change; the great majority only discussed resilience in terms of physical infrastructure protection for established citizens.

6.3 International Climate Finance — The GCF and Adaptation Fund

The most important resource mobilization for climate adaptation in developing nations is represented by the international climate finance framework, but its track record on social protection and governance reform is seriously flawed. Seawalls, drainage systems, early warning systems, and renewable energy installations are among the large-scale infrastructure projects that have been authorized by the Green Climate Fund, which has a capitalization of around USD 12.8 billion during its first two replenishment cycles (GCF, 2024). Figure 2 shows that the combined share of authorized funds for social protection and governance reform is remarkably low.

Figure 2: Green Climate Fund Approved Portfolio — Allocation by Thematic Area (2015–2024, % of approved funding)

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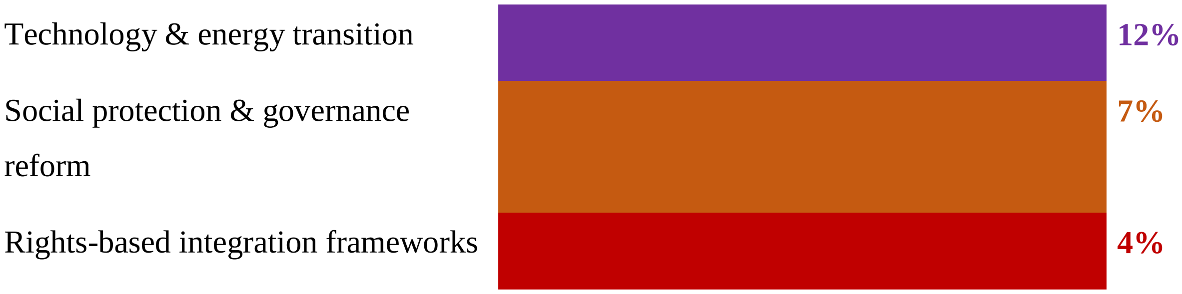

Source: Authors' analysis of GCF Project Database (GCF, 2024). N = 243 approved projects as of December 2024. Thematic categorisation follows GCF result areas; some projects span multiple categories and are allocated proportionally. Note: 'Rights-based integration frameworks' is a sub-category of the broader governance and social protection allocation.

6.4 The Humanitarian–Development Nexus and Its Limits

Since the 2016 World Humanitarian Summit, the humanitarian-development nexus concept, which aims to connect immediate disaster aid with long-term development planning, has become more and more popular. The nexus concept has significant advantages in the context of climate migration: it acknowledges that displacement is often long-term rather than short-term, and it gives development actors institutional space to interact in settings that were previously only available to humanitarian responders (Barbelet, 2021). However, when it comes to slow-onset climate displacement, the nexus architecture has serious drawbacks.

6.5 Participatory Upgrading and Community-Led Approaches

Perhaps the most promising model for migrant-inclusive urban government now available is community-led urban upgrading initiatives, most notably those connected to Shack/Slum Dwellers International (SDI) and groups like BRAC in Bangladesh and CARE International in Mali. These initiatives combine systematic attempts to involve migrant communities in participatory planning procedures with tenure regularization, gradual infrastructure supply, and community savings plans (Mitlin & Satterthwaite, 2013; Barbelet, 2021). Research from Bangladesh, Kenya, India, and South Africa indicates that even in highly mixed, high-turnover communities that include recent climate immigrants, participatory upgrading can result in notable improvements in housing quality, tenure security, and social cohesion when it is well-designed and sufficiently funded (Mitlin & Satterthwaite, 2013). The main limitation is scale: current programs are mostly sponsored by foreign non-governmental organizations and operate at the neighborhood or district level, with little ownership by the local government. The difficulty is in integrating participatory upgrading ideas into large-scale

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municipal planning processes; this is more of a governance reform agenda issue than a project delivery one.

7. Towards Adaptive Urban Integration: A Conceptual Model

The evidence reviewed in this chapter indicates that effective governance responses to climate-induced migration require a fundamental reconceptualization of the relationship between urban citizenship, climate adaptation, and development finance rather than small modifications to existing instruments. This section presents a new conceptual framework called the Adaptive Urban Integration (AUI) Model, which aims to provide this reconceptualization with both practical policy architecture and analytical clarity. As discussed in Sections 3 through 5, each of the three interrelated pillars that comprise the framework addresses a distinct facet of the marginalization process. Those are discussed one by one here, so first of all is The Three-Pillar Architecture. According to the AUI Model, sustainable integration for climate migrants necessitates concurrent advancement in three areas, as shown in Figure 3. These pillars are mutually constitutive conditions rather than sequential stages: political inclusion without material provisioning results in nominal rights that cannot be exercised; institutional recognition without political inclusion results in administrative categories without agency; and material provisioning without institutional recognition results in dependent welfare recipients rather than citizens with rights. Therefore, the model explicitly opposes piecemeal, single-pillar methods, such as the legal-status-centric approach of refugee law reform or the infrastructure-centric approach of the GCF.

Figure 3: The Adaptive Urban Integration (AUI) Model — Three-Pillar Conceptual Framework

PILLAR I Material Provisioning	PILLAR II Institutional Recognition	PILLAR III Political Inclusion
‣ Formal land tenure ‣ Housing access ‣ Basic service delivery ‣ Social protection floors ‣ Climate-linked infrastructure	‣ Civil registration ‣ Legal identity documents ‣ Rights portability ‣ Migrant advisory boards ‣ IDP legal frameworks	‣ Participatory budgeting ‣ Subnational voting rights ‣ Anti-discrimination law ‣ Community representation ‣ Cultural recognition

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Source: Authors' original framework. Pillar structure draws conceptually on Mitlin & Satterthwaite (2013), Parnell & Oldfield (2014), and Barnett & Webber (2010). Indicators are illustrative; context-specific calibration required.

Secondly, Operationalisation and Indicators need to be discussed where its explicit that Only when its three pillars are converted into quantifiable indicators that can be monitored over time and in various circumstances does the AUI Model become analytically useful. A preliminary indicator framework for each pillar is shown in Table 5, along with the policy levers that are most directly related to promoting development at the local, national, and international levels.

Table 5: AUI Model — Pillar Indicators and Policy Levers

Pillar	Core Objective	Operationalisation Indicators	Policy Levers
I. Material Provisioning	Guarantee minimum standard of physical security and service access	% of climate migrants with formal land tenure; housing quality index; access to water/sanitation/health/education	Inclusive urban master plans; climate-linked social housing quotas; universal basic service mandates
II. Institutional Recognition	Confer legal status and administrative identity enabling rights exercise	% with civil registration; portability of social entitlements across jurisdictions; migrant representation in urban planning committees	National IDP legislation; digital identity systems; migrant advisory boards in municipal governance
III. Political Inclusion	Extend participatory citizenship rights to mobile populations	Participation rate in local elections; presence of migrant civil society in policy forums; anti-discrimination legal protections	Inclusive zoning reform; participatory budgeting with migrant community representation;

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Pillar	**Core Objective**	**Operationalisation Indicators**	**Policy Levers**
			subnational political rights

Source: Authors' original framework. Indicators draw on UN-Habitat Urban Indicators Programme (2022), World Bank Climate Migration Measurement Framework (2022), and IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix methodology (IOM, 2022).

Thirdly, Scalar Policy Architecture, where The AUI Model clearly acknowledges that no one level of governance possesses the skills or resources necessary to carry out all three pillars on its own. Thus, a multi-scalar policy architecture is crucial. The integration of climate in-migration as an explicit variable in urban master plans, zoning laws, and service delivery planning—moving climate migrants from administrative invisibility to planning visibility—is the most significant reform at the municipal level. Even though none of them were created especially for climate migration contexts, municipal governments that have implemented inclusive planning strategies—such as Medellín's urban acupuncture model, Durban's climate change adaptation plan, and Indore's participatory slum upgrading program—offer transferable institutional lessons (Parnell & Oldfield, 2014; UN-Habitat, 2022).

The creation of national legislative frameworks for climate-displaced individuals that assign precise departmental responsibilities, build common data systems, and set basic service entitlement requirements independent of migrants' administrative classification is the key reform at the national level. Such frameworks are lacking in Bangladesh, Vietnam, Niger, and Mali; their creation would be a significant institutional advancement. Without establishing new institutional frameworks, national adaptation plans (NAPs), which are currently mandated by UNFCCC procedures, offer a means of incorporating climate migration rules (Warner & Afifi, 2014).

Two reforms are crucial on a global scale. First, in order to operationalize the idea that institutions are infrastructure, the climate financing architecture—more especially, the GCF and Adaptation Fund—must refocus its portfolio toward social protection, rights-based integration, and governance reform. Second, regional and bilateral agreements that provide accountability mechanisms for climate-receiving governments should gradually formalize the Global Compact for Migration's non-binding obligations addressing migration as adaptation (Objective 2) (UNHCR, 2023; IOM, 2022).

Then , lastly Reconceptualising Urban Citizenship is dicussed which mentions that the most normatively difficult aspect of the framework's argument—the necessity of rethinking urban citizenship in the post-colonial city—is the foundation of the AUI Model's third pillar, political inclusion. In developing nations, the prevailing conception of urban citizenship views political engagement as dependent on formal residency registration, which necessitates job verification, legal tenure, and frequently familial ties to the receiving city. According to Parnell and Oldfield (2014), this idea deliberately keeps climate migrants—as well as other migratory populations—out of the political groups whose decisions have the biggest impact on their lives. The AUI Model promotes a territorial, as opposed to registration-based, understanding of urban citizenship, which holds that residents and employees of a city, regardless of their official administrative status, have a right to participate in its administration.

Although this idea is not new—it draws from a long history of urban rights theory, from Harvey (2008) to Lefebvre's (1968) right to the city to modern urban social movements—its application to climate migrants in the Global South is still underdeveloped.

8. Conclusion: Cities as the Frontline of Climate Justice

This chapter has made the case that migration brought on by climate change into the cities of Global South represents a structural governance dilemma with five analytically different but complementary features. First, governance responses necessitate long-horizon urban planning tools rather than emergency relief frameworks; the prevailing humanitarian policy architecture, which is based on episodic disaster response, is institutionally insufficient for the slow-onset environmental stressors that drive most climate displacement events. Second, whether climate migrants are integrated or marginalized depends on urban governance ability, not just location or affluence. Since institutions are more important than endowments, governance reform is the most effective way to intervene. Third, the national policy responses function in institutional department that result in conflicting interventions and put communities displaced by climate change in regulatory situation of not taking any actions as the communities are waiting for the governments to take actions; a successful response requires the integration of mandates related to urban growth, migration, and climate change. Fourth, a technocratic bias that consistently investing less than what is required in the institutional and human capital, necessary for long-term adaptation is reproduced by the international climate financing architecture. Fifth, For climate migrants to achieve long-term social integration, urban citizenship must be rethought in a way that extends political affiliation to mobile people. This transcends both the post-colonial replication of formal citizenship as a tool of elite territorial control and the legacy of colonial administrative exclusion.

The Sustainable Development Goals are directly impacted by these arguments. In situations where cities are taking in millions of climate migrants without the governance capacity to integrate them, SDG 11—sustainable cities—cannot be accomplished; inclusive, safe, and resilient cities necessitate explicit climate migration governance as a fundamental element of urban development strategy. The social and institutional aspects of adaptation, particularly migrant integration, must be specifically supported and monitored in order to accomplish SDG 13— The normative basis for the rights-based integration framework presented in this chapter is provided by SDG 16—peace, justice, and strong institutions. The commitment of SDG 16 to inclusive governance and legal identity for all are incompatible with administrative invisibility and legal statelessness for populations displaced by climate change.

This chapter presents a significant research agenda. To create reliable causal attribution techniques that can differentiate between migration driven by the environment and migration driven by economic factors over the whole range of slow-onset and sudden-onset causes, quantitative research is required. To comprehend how governance ability may be developed in secondary cities under circumstances of financial strain and political marginalization, institutional study is required. To determine whether governance features—institutional arrangements, planning instruments, and political economies—produce better results for climate migrants even under comparable structural restrictions, comparative urban studies are required. In order to develop the content of a rethought urban citizenship appropriate for the climatic period, normative political philosophy is also required.

The front lines of climate justice are cities. The least responsible populations are most directly affected by the effects of global greenhouse gas emissions in the peri-urban settlements of Dhaka, Bamako, and Phnom Penh. As this chapter has demonstrated, whether such effects result in long-term poverty or social integration is a political and institutional matter, and as such, it admits political and institutional responses. The analytical and prescriptive framework presented here contributes to those solutions, fully aware of the enormous scope of the governance transformation needed, the limited time available, and the need for the best possible scholarship, policy, and practice for the populations whose lives depend on it.

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